



Sri Lanka

India conceded strategic ground to China and Pakistan and has not pushed Rajapakse hard enough on the Tamil issue.

AP PHOTO/ GEMUNU AMARASINGHE



Nepal

Chinese influence is growing and the Maoists have fallen out with India and a weak PM Madhav Nepal has made India jittery.

AP PHOTO



ASEAN

Despite the decade-old Look East policy, India is yet to sign a free trade agreement with ASEAN countries, a loss of time and opportunity.

SIPRA DAS



Africa

Even though it was a first mover, India has been outsmarted by China because of its timidity and lack of sustained interest.

AP PHOTO/ISNA, ALIREZA SOTAKBAR



Iran

Iran views India with suspicion following the vote against it at the IAEA under US pressure. Iran-Pakistan gas pipeline in cold storage.

efforts to build nuclear weapons, India didn't help relations with it by voting for sanctions against it in the IAEA, seemingly under US pressure. In Central Asia, India has failed to cash in on the tremendous amount of goodwill that it had built up in the Commonwealth of Independent States, especially during the Soviet era. China, on the other hand, has made these countries its economic backyard. The only exception has been Afghanistan where India's engagement has been nothing short of brilliant—indicating that if Delhi makes a planned and determined effort it can excel.

The overall picture on the way India's foreign policy is being conducted is gloomy. "India is now regarded a soft state," says Brajesh Mishra, a former national security adviser. This is at a time when India is considered as an emerging global power with its economy growing at an impressive rate. As K.C. Singh, a former secretary in the Ministry of External Affairs (MEA), points out: "A newly Independent India in 1947, militarily and economically fragile, operated out of moral strength; today despite India being an emerging global power we are negotiating out of self doubt and fear." The real reason is that unlike China there is no coherence to India's foreign policy. "In the absence of a distinct strategic doctrine, India's foreign policy has become increasingly ad hoc," says Brahma Chellaney, professor at the Centre for Policy Research. Part of the reason is the uncertainty that has set in after the economic meltdown. Most countries are unclear as to how things will shape up and are hedging their relations with everyone—competing and cooperating at the same time. Sumit Ganguly, a US-based policy expert, says: "Economic clout is a key decider and India needs to be more aggressive to push its agenda."

So what should India do? To define India's national interests, the MEA commissioned ICRIER, the Delhi-based economic think tank, to conduct a study. ICRIER's director Rajiv Kumar says, "The consensus was security and economic prosperity and these had to walk as two feet without trade-offs. The neighbourhood remained the most important concern and the other issue was the need for India to play a role in global governance." If coalesced, these strands could form the basis for India's foreign policy. Essentially these could translate into ensuring peace at the borders, retaining India's strategic autonomy and working for economic prosperity through trade. To paraphrase Franklin D. Roosevelt, India now has nothing to fear but fear itself.

with Saurabh Shukla